

Psalms 86

Unite My Heart

Teach me thy way... unite my heart to fear thy name
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Bow down thine ear, O LORD, hear me: for I am poor and needy.
- 2 Preserve my soul; for I am holy: O thou my God, save thy servant that trusteth in thee.
- 3 Be merciful unto me, O Lord: for I cry unto thee daily.
- 4 Rejoice the soul of thy servant: for unto thee, O Lord, do I lift up my soul.
- 5 For thou, Lord, art good, and ready to forgive; and plenteous in mercy unto all them that call upon thee.
- 6 Give ear, O LORD, unto my prayer; and attend to the voice of my supplications.
- 7 In the day of my trouble I will call upon thee: for thou wilt answer me.
- 8 Among the gods there is none like unto thee, O Lord; neither are there any works like unto thy works.
- 9 All nations whom thou hast made shall come and worship before thee, O Lord; and shall glorify thy name.
- 10 For thou art great, and doest wondrous things: thou art God alone.
- 11 Teach me thy way, O LORD; I will walk in thy truth: unite my heart to fear thy name.
- 12 I will praise thee, O Lord my God, with all my heart: and I will glorify thy name for evermore.
- 13 For great is thy mercy toward me: and thou hast delivered my soul from the lowest hell.
- 14 O God, the proud are risen against me, and the assemblies of violent men have sought after my soul; and have not set thee before them.
- 15 But thou, O Lord, art a God full of compassion, and gracious, longsuffering, and plenteous in mercy and truth.
- 16 O turn unto me, and have mercy upon me; give thy strength unto thy servant, and save the son of thine handmaid.
- 17 Show me a token for good; that they which hate me may see it, and be ashamed: because thou, LORD, hast helped me, and comforted me.

2 · CONTEXT

A personal prayer of David combining urgent petition, confident praise of God's incomparable mercy, and a specific request for undivided devotion. Unlike psalms dominated by external threat alone, this one is equally concerned with internal integrity—asking not just for rescue but for a heart that is unified rather than scattered between competing loyalties. Henry treats verse 11 as the psalm's spiritual center: the request to have one heart wholly set on God rather than divided allegiances.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

The prayer opens with humble self-description—poor and needy—and requests for preservation, mercy, and rejoicing, grounded simply in the fact that the psalmist trusts and cries out to God daily. The plea is personal and direct: bow your ear, hear me, gladden the soul of your servant.

Verse 5-7

Confidence rests on God's revealed character: good, ready to forgive, abundant in mercy to all who call on Him. The petition repeats with specific confidence that in the day of trouble, when he calls, God will answer.

Verse 8-10

Praise widens into a declaration of God's uniqueness: among all so-called gods, none compares, none does what He does. All nations, it is declared, will eventually come and worship before Him and glorify His name, because He alone is great and does wondrous things.

Verse 11-13

The psalm's heart: teach me your way, that I may walk in your truth, and unite my heart to fear your name—a plainly stated request for undivided devotion rather than a heart pulled between competing loyalties. This is followed by a vow to praise with a whole heart and glorify God's name forever, grounded in the great mercy that has already delivered his soul from the depths.

Verse 14-17

The crisis returns to view: proud and violent men have risen against him, giving no thought to God at all. The response is to recite God's character again—merciful, gracious, longsuffering, abundant in mercy and truth—asking for a visible sign of favor that would put his enemies to shame and make clear that God Himself has helped and comforted him.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Prayer for external deliverance and prayer for internal integrity belong together; a divided heart, pulled between competing loyalties, is as real a danger to the believer as any outward enemy. The specific request of verse 11—to have a heart united and undivided in fearing God—names a need that most external threats cannot address, yet which is essential to genuine faithfulness.

Application for life today.

Alongside whatever external difficulty you are praying about, ask yourself honestly whether your heart is currently 'united' toward God or divided between Him and other competing loyalties or fears. Make verse 11 a specific, recurring prayer rather than a vague aspiration: 'unite my heart to fear your name.' Let the psalm's rehearsal of God's character (vv. 5, 15) become your own default response whenever proud or hostile opposition rises against you.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. In what area of life does your heart currently feel divided rather than 'united' in fearing God (v. 11)?

2. How does declaring God's character—merciful, gracious, abundant in truth (vv. 5, 15)—before asking for help change the posture of your prayer?

3. What specific 'token for good' (v. 17) might you be watching for, or need to ask God for, in a current difficulty?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).